

Health Choices and Well-Being

Exploring Influences and Skills



 In this activity, you will reflect on the influences affecting your health, analyze the impact of substances, and build practical skills for healthy decision-making.

Welcome to your Health journey

Every day, you make choices that impact your physical and mental well-being. Understanding the forces behind these decisions helps you stay in control of your future. In this guide, you will explore how brain development, media messages, and social influences shape your path.

Key Term	Definition
Adolescence	A period of growth between childhood and adulthood where the brain undergoes significant development.
Refusal Skills	Techniques used to confidently say no to situations that conflict with your personal values or goals.
Coping Strategies	Healthy methods used to manage stress and difficult emotions in a positive way.

Read the essential facts

Read the following information carefully. As you read, ask yourself: How do these factors influence the goals I have for my own future?

The adolescent brain is a work in progress. During the teenage years, the brain is actively fine-tuning its decision-making centers. This makes it a time of high energy, but also high sensitivity to peer influence and risky behaviors.

Substances like nicotine, alcohol, and other drugs can interfere with this growth process. They often disrupt memory, mood, and long-term planning capabilities. Understanding these effects is not just about avoiding danger; it is about protecting your ability to pursue your passions and achieve your future goals.

Critical thinking is your best tool. When you analyze media messages or peer pressure, you can identify what is real and what is a marketing tactic. By practicing refusal skills and building healthy coping habits, you take charge of your personal story.



Building connections and understanding

Use your knowledge from the text and your own experience to complete the table below.

Key Concept	Your Understanding	Why is this important?
Peer Influence	<i>The pressure to fit in with friends.</i>	<i>It helps us understand why we might feel pressured to make certain choices.</i>
Brain Development	Write your answer here	Write your answer here
Healthy Coping		
+ Add a row or column as needed		



Try it out

Use what you learned to solve the problems below.

Scenario-based Question	Response
A friend offers you a vape after school. How do you respond while staying true to your goals?	Write your answer here
You feel overwhelmed by stress during a busy week. Which coping strategy will you use?	
How do you determine if a source of health information is credible?	



Show what you learned

Now, create a project that shows what you learned. You will design a Public Service Announcement (PSA) plan to help others understand the importance of making healthy choices. Use Magic Media or Elements to help visualise or record your idea.

- Identify your target audience.
- Draft a clear, positive message about healthy choices.
- Choose one important scientific fact from the text to include.
- List a resource or support system for students in need.

[Double click to design here]



Reflect on your learning

Reflect on the work you have completed regarding influences, health effects, and decision-making skills.

How would you explain the connection between brain development and the importance of saying no to substance use?

[Write your answer here.]

Which personal influence (friends, family, social media) do you find strongest, and what is one way you can manage that influence?

What is one specific healthy coping strategy you plan to use when you feel stressed this month?

Teaching note



This activity packet covers critical health standards regarding substance use and decision-making. Students may need additional support when identifying trusted adults or community resources. Please review the 'Help Map' section with students to ensure they know who to contact in their specific school or community context. This was generated by AI to give you a head start — not the final word. You know your students best, so give it a once-over and make it yours.